

FOREWORD

I don't yet fully understand the compulsion that drew me to the life of a soldier. Certainly there was a tradition of military service in my family; but there was an invisible, more powerful force that was above family tradition. Kipling once wrote that "Irishmen move to the sound of guns like salmon to the sea". Perhaps it is just so. The regiments in which I served, the Royal Irish, with over three hundred years of history and the much younger Special Air Service, have both left an indelible mark on me. It was the regiments that made me the man I am.

Increasingly in modern societies, the affluent first world, where military service is reserved for the daring and the inspired, the privilege of belonging to a professional army unit is still an experience that changes the individual, their outlook, and how the world perceives them. It is also extremely expensive for the nations to maintain such forces – with the largest portion going on salaries. Has it not always been the case that elite fighting men command a premium?

Societies have raised and maintained these standing fighting elites since before written records. Many were the preserve of kings and emperors, while others, like the Zulu *impis* or the Spartan regiments, embodied a warrior code that was woven into the very fabric of their society. Some were privileged elites, set apart from society like Napoleon's Imperial Guard, and some even became so influential that they challenged the very power of the state they were created to protect, like the Ottoman janissaries did in the 18th century.

But one thing remains consistent; the military organizations from across the millennia reflect the society from which they are drawn and are underpinned and motivated by the standards of that society. They reflect not just the values of the society but the way in which those societies wish to see themselves. Essentially it is the way that societies organize their fighting forces that gives those forces their unique qualities. In Asian societies the martial tradition is preserved within tribes and castes. In Japan it was formalized under the code of *bushido*, the "warrior's way".

